

Christian gender roles are anti-woman

The definition of 'anti-woman' specifies behaviour or ideologies which deem women as inferior and subordinate to men. In the context of Christian gender roles, 'anti-woman' can be seen as a role which limits and **violates** the autonomy and agency of a female and aims to devalue or oppress women. While it might be argued that Christian gender roles are anti-woman as the Bible seems to prescribe fixed gender roles of a child bearer, mother or virgin limiting women's intellectual capabilities and individual liberty, this is ultimately ineffective. This is because, while it is undeniable that historically Christian gender roles were anti-woman as females were condemned to fulfil such functions that they may not have desired, roles are something that we construct socially and hence Christian gender roles are not anti-woman. Within today's society, we see women occupy roles typically dominated by men within Christianity, therefore this thesis can be convincingly argued.

Firstly, one might argue Christian gender roles are anti-woman as, biblically, women have subordinate roles in comparison to their male counterparts. Women were presented as inferior, perceived as physically weaker, more emotional and ultimately lacking in rational, intellectual abilities and this shaped views within the Roman catholic denomination. In Genesis 2, it is indicated that Adam was created first, and that Eve's role was solely to be a "suitable helper for him" as God thought that "it is not good for the man to be alone." Additionally, it is indicated that Eve was made from Adam as God "made a woman from the rib he had taken out of the man" (Genesis 2:22). This shaped Eve's role as a helper and her existence dependent upon Adam, serving only to meet his needs and requirements. From this, the Roman Catholic, Eastern Orthodox and Protestant traditions restricted the ordained ministry to men. Further supporting women as inferior is Timothy 2:12 "I do not permit a woman to teach or to exercise authority over a man; rather, she is to remain quiet" and Jesus only choosing male apostles (Mark 3:13-19). As a result, due to women being rejected an independent role and viewed as solely a helper to man, gender roles are anti-woman.

However, one could postulate that the Hebrew term for 'helper' is 'ezer' and was not intended to present a woman's role as inferior, but in fact as an equal to man. In Psalm 33:20, God is described as 'ezer' ("Our soul waits for the Lord; He is our help (ezer) and our shield") detailing that this is a term implying strength and support, not subordination, yet we have misinterpreted God's word which has manifested in us fabricating gender roles that are anti-woman. Eve is a

sufficient, not necessary condition for Adam's completion, and hence can be seen as a partner of equal value. This details a symbiotic relationship between Adam and Eve where both are dependent on one another to fulfil their desires. As a result, it can be contended that the Christian gender roles of a woman being a 'helper' is not innately anti-woman, but we have interpreted it under a patriarchal light.

Therefore, one might appeal to another of a woman's gender role in Christianity: the ability to fulfil the role of birthing and raising a child, which is anti-woman. This stemmed from the repercussions of the Fall where for all women God made "pains in childbearing very severe" and labour to children painful (Genesis 3). This is anti-woman as a woman's identity is strictly attached to her ability to give birth to children, and also explicitly perpetuates a male-dominated hierarchy. The Roman Catholic view further supports this as in the *Mulieris Dignitatem*, Pope John Paul II argued that Mary's role was the 'theotokos' (God-bearer). The incarnation of God and salvation seems contingent upon Jesus being born from a human mother. This clearly stipulates that Mary became significant by her ability to birth Jesus, becoming consumed by her role of motherhood. From this, she became united with God and involved in a divine plan and attained the "supernatural elevation to union with God" that all of humanity aspires to achieve in the afterlife. However, Mary became an archetype for a woman and her individual liberty or agency was not respected: "she is truly the Mother of God, because motherhood concerns the whole person, not just the body." Further heightened, the Pope contended women are 'naturally disposed to motherhood' physically, due to their womb and also psychologically as motherhood creates 'special openness' in a mother to their child such that mothers develop altruistic abilities and compassion, suited to raise a child. The fulfilment and natural telos of the female personality thus appears to come from motherhood. As a result, because Christianity appears to define a woman through their ability to succeed in the role of raising children, one could put forward such roles fail to respect the autonomy and dignity of women.

However, one might challenge this notion by postulating that while Christian gender roles entail that women fulfil childbearing responsibilities and raise offspring, this is not seen as inherently anti-woman given evidence from evolutionary biology. Biology could support the divinely ordained roles that distinguish men and women and therefore defining 'woman' purely in biological terms would be to recognise the unique reproductive capacity of female bodies as central to the survival of the human species. This can align with God's intention for humanity. This would therefore offer a justification for Christian gender roles of the woman to be to reproduce and raise

offspring. Females are naturally adapted to gestation, childbirth and nursing with physical and hormonal systems specialised to carry out these processes. Sexual dimorphism reflects reproductive strategies: the female pelvis, hormonal cycles and mammary glands detail the way females are innately suited to such roles. Additionally, one might appeal to hormonal influences (estrogen, oxytocin) which affects emotional reactivity as research indicates that the amygdala (brain region for processing emotions) may respond more strongly to negative emotional stimuli providing evidence as to why women are more emotional and therefore better catered for subordinate roles, and men who are less emotional therefore occupy leadership roles.

Nevertheless, the biological view does not provide a successful justification for Christian gender roles. Even if we accept evidence that women are less suited to occupy leadership roles, Hume (*A Treatise of Human Nature*) indicated that one should not move from descriptive, factual statements (women are more emotional due to biology) to prescriptive statements that entail duties (hence women should not fulfil management roles and should stick to childbearing and raising children). Hume elaborates that one cannot logically derive an 'ought' from an 'is' alone as it requires sufficient justification, needing a moral principle connecting the fact to the prescription. Additionally, we can challenge the evidence from the study as these hormonal influences are small and don't apply universally, hence there is insufficient evidence to make a generalisation that women are more emotional than men. We can also use the 2003 study which indicates that women's perceived emotionality is a result of social and cultural conditioning and not rooted within evolutionary biology or the intrinsic way a woman was born. Chaplin and Aldao exposed how from childhood girls are encouraged to express feelings, while boys are discouraged indicating the way that it is a result of environmental factors not biological. As a result, Christian gender roles would be seen as anti-woman due to the lack of scientific evidence to support or justify that women should be confined to procreation and raising children.

However, in alignment with Tribble, one might argue God's intention was for man and woman to be equal, yet a male-dominated society was only the ramification of succumbing to temptation and sin. This can be demonstrated through Galatians 3:28 which argues that "there is neither male nor female: for all are one in Christ Jesus." All of humanity was made in the likeness and image of God (Genesis 1) and hence it follows that God wanted this. Also, Tribble contends that both the man and woman disobey God and are equally responsible: yet, interestingly, the woman actually shows intelligence and initiative in dialoguing with the serpent whereas the man acts passive with the offering of the fruit. Likewise, the consequence "your husband shall rule over

you" (Genesis 3:16) is not a divine command or endorsement, but a description of the broken relationship that results from sin. In essence, Tribble contends that patriarchy is a result of sin and not God's intention since in the prelapsarian state, there was harmony and mutuality, yet only in the postlapsarian state was there male domination.

While it seems that God's intention was for equality, one could contend that God's intention is irrelevant and simply doesn't matter. What is of moral pertinence is the Christian gender roles that we construct from God's word, no matter if this is the correct or incorrect interpretation. As Daly argues, the anthropomorphic language used to describe God is essentially male as Christian imagery of God as Father, Christ as Son and church hierarchies led by men normalise men as spiritual and social authorities. Additionally, the Pope recognises that men and women are 'equal but different' indicating that women are seen as equal in value yet still seen as different within roles they occupy. This can be seen through the Pope's presentation of virginity as a way of union with Christ in heaven, and as a confirmation of women's dignity beyond motherhood. If a woman chooses virginity freely, her worth is not contingent on marriage or childbearing. However, it still centres a female's worth around their sexuality rather than respecting their individuality, humanity and contributions beyond the role of a virgin or mother. It also violates their moral autonomy as an individual by placing emphasis on sexual purity as it may limit their desires to engage in sexual relationships outside of marriage. Furthermore, it reinforces male dependence as it upholds male-dominated priesthood and celebrates women's virginity, reinforcing these traditional stereotypes of women to be passive and submissive. As a result, since this limits a woman's liberty, as we have fabricated roles such as being a virgin and being a mother to women within Christianity, this is anti-woman, regardless if it was God's intention or not.

However, we can convincingly contend that as a society we have evolved and reinterpreted the bible to better respect women's rights and dignity, to now be seen as not anti-woman. Historical examples such as Deborah (Judges 4-5) as a prophetess and judge of Israel, leading Israel in battle against oppression, and Phoebe (Romans 16:1-2) as a 'diakonos' of the Church and being entrusted to deliver Paul's letter, making her a leader, and Junia (Romans 16:7) who is finally recognised as a female apostle despite historical attempts to masculinise her name, indicate the way that women are being better recognised by society within the Bible and therefore Christian gender roles today support and encourage women to flourish. The equality of men and women can be further supported by a liberal protestant viewpoint in which women are able to hold positions of power within these churches through their roles of ministers, bishops and priests. The Church of England ordains women as priests since 1994 and bishops since 2015, exemplified by

Libby Lane becoming the first female bishop in the Church of England, and the evangelical Lutheran church has ordained women since 1970. In 2006, Katharine Jefferts Schori became the first woman elected as Bishop of the Episcopal Church (USA). The liberal protestant view also places less emphasis on the Virgin Mary, rejecting that the sole purpose of a woman 'theotokos' and indicating that Mary should not overshadow Christ or become a focus of worship. While parenthood is still valued, this value is not tied exclusively to women or to a mandate that women must become mothers. Due to the progressions made within Christianity detailing that women can fulfil roles typically dominated by men, and the possibility for women to occupy leadership roles, exercising their liberty and autonomy, it can be argued that Christian gender roles are not anti-woman.

While it might be tempting to put forward that Christian gender roles are anti-woman, since a woman's role was seen in many denominations to be a 'helper' to men, a 'child-bearer' or a virgin. This seems to limit their capacity to exercise free will and individual autonomy as a woman. However, this is ultimately ineffective if we take into consideration the progress within our society as we have re-defined roles, making male-dominated roles available for women to occupy. As a result, due to a departure from attaching a woman's worth to their success at motherhood or fulfilling the needs of their husband, and an improving encouragement for women to take on leadership roles, it can be persuasively contended that Christian gender roles are not anti-woman.